trying here.

The reaction regarding one of India's most publicized undertrials, Phoolan Devi,* was expressed by Meena Lukre, assistant superintendent of the jail:

> Phoolan came to our jail after having spent 11 years in Gwalior [a city in Madhya Pradesh, about 320 km from Delhi]. We put her in a separate cell and asked some of our more humane convicts to stay with her. They were the ones who would ensure that she had her medicines on time (she was suspected to be suffering from cancer, which was ruled out here) and generally got her responding to the humane environment. I persuaded her to take up some activity like sewing or knitting but she couldn't keep it up for long. But she took to learning. Today she can take dictation and enjoys reading the light books we give her. Now she maintains that had she been given this opportunity earlier, she would not have wasted these 11 years.

Those who have experienced the previous regimes and the earlier conditions were apprehensive about the possibility of this changed environment continuing. The main question bothering them was: 'What will happen when the present IG is transferred? One wrong posting and everything would be undone.' This was the common apprehension voiced by a large number of persons. But Sarita, charged with the murder of her husband, who was then waiting for her trial to start, could not keep the amazement out of her voice:

> I thought it would be terrible. I had visions of prisoners being beaten with sticks, being made to do all sorts of dirty jobs. We would not be able to move about. I was almost hysterical with fear. But when I came here I was amazed. This did not seem like a prison at all. There were classes going on, people were busy with different things and everyone had something to do. This was more of a women's hostel than anything else.

'What's changed now', explained Urmilla Rana, the matron of the women's ward, 'is that now they can at least do something with their time. Earlier there was nothing for them except to be locked up in their cells or to be let out for sometime in the courtyard. Most of them would only talk about their cases and be crying all the time. They were irritable and angry and fights would break out over the smallest of things. Of course, punishments were frequent; that was the only way to keep them in check. That made some of them worse and they would take it out on the others. Now they have lots to do. Their day is spent in education classes, or sewing, or knitting, or in yoga classes. The tension has been reduced very much and naturally this has led to a drastic reduction in fights and quarrels.'

Children up to four years of age also 'spent time' with their mothers in jail. A recent count showed that there were 40 such children in the ladies' ward. 'It used to be heart-rending,' admitted Meena Lukre, herself a mother of two, 'when a child would tell me, "okay aunty, I have to go and get locked up". The cell was their home, and going home meant being locked up.'

'The mothers would not look after them; they would not bathe them or care for them. They would be moving about in rags. When the new IG (P) saw this she was moved,' added Meena.

Moved indeed, and moved to immediate action. The Social Welfare Department of the Delhi Administration was contacted and outings were organized for the children. They were taken to the Raj Ghat lawns and to the Delhi Zoo. The only humans they had ever seen were women, and so everybody was 'aunty' to them. The only animals they had seen were the two cats in the ward, Sheru and Chein Chein, and the birds that visited it. Thus, the peacock was to them a 'big bird' and the buffalo 'a very